

Four questions, and your path

What a Retreat Can and Cannot Do

Answer honestly. Keep this page private. The path you choose is a private reflection, not a test.

When support comes first. Some situations need support before or during a retreat. These are important examples, not a complete list.

- **Thoughts of not wanting to be alive.** Do not rely on this retreat as your response. Tell a trusted person and contact a qualified mental-health professional or crisis service promptly. If you believe you may act on those thoughts, have made a plan, or cannot keep yourself safe, contact your local emergency services or go to the nearest emergency department now, and ask someone trustworthy to stay with you.

- **Abuse, past or present.** If you are being harmed now, your immediate priority is safety. A private retreat is not a substitute for specialist support or a safety plan. Contact a domestic-abuse service using a safe device if possible.

- **Dependence on alcohol, sedatives or another substance.** Do not use a retreat to stop suddenly without medical advice; withdrawal from some substances can be dangerous. Speak with a doctor or addiction service first.

- **Trauma reactions.** If silence, prayer or recalling the past tends to bring flashbacks, panic or dissociation, plan the retreat with a qualified trauma-informed professional, and consider a shorter or supported format.

- **Medical advice not to be alone,** or if you are unsure whether solitude is safe for you now: seek professional guidance before you begin.

Postponing is not failing.

1. After this lesson, is there any support you need to arrange before you begin? Write it down, and write down when you will arrange it.

2. Who is the person you will call if a session becomes too much? Have you told them? Do you also know how to reach professional or crisis help if needed?

3. What are you hoping the retreat itself will accomplish? Mark anything that belongs in the "cannot" list. You may still bring every desire to God, but separate what you are asking of God from what you are expecting your retreat to produce.

4. Which of the four paths are you choosing?

- ☐ **Proceed independently.** You feel stable, safe alone, and able to pause when needed.
- ☐ **Proceed with support.** Arrange regular contact with a trusted person or professional during the retreat.
- ☐ **Use an adapted format.** Choose a shorter, guided or group version (Lesson 6).
- ☐ **Postpone for now.** Seek professional, medical, crisis or safety support first. Postponing is not failing.